GEMS OF INDIA

**INDIA HEALTH FUND, TATA TRUSTS,** *Mumbai*

***Key person:*** **Madhav Joshi,** CEO
***Year of inception:*** **2017**

# REDUCING THE DISEASE BURDEN

**AI diagnostics, clinical decisions, disease surveillance—IHF is backing tech start-ups to reimagine public healthcare around India's lived realities**

*By* **M.G. ARUN**

**From his office in Mumbai's iconic Elphinstone Building**, Madhav Joshi, CEO of India Health Fund (IHF), often reflects on the building's quiet legacy. It was here that Ratan Tata spent his final working years as chairman emeritus of Tata Sons and chairman of Tata Trusts. It was also here, Joshi says, that Tata's vision took institutional shape: that technology-led innovation could make a meaningful difference in healthcare delivery.

Founded in 2017 by Tata Trusts, IHF's mission was ambitious—to eliminate infectious diseases and reduce public health risks in domains where private capital rarely ventures. And how was that to be achieved? By funding start-up technologies that diagnose faster, work more accurately and yet remain affordable.

The timing was critical. India had announced targets to eliminate tuberculosis by 2025, malaria by 2027, and sharply reduce maternal and child mortality. "Innovation based on science and technology was identified as a potential disruptor," Joshi says, one that could help public programmes close the gap between policy and outcomes. When he joined IHF in 2020, the challenge felt immediate—sharpened further by COVID-19, which brought into focus how innovation could transform diagnosis and treatment.

Today, IHF positions itself as a rare global experiment: private philanthropic capital from a developing country backing solutions built in that country, for the developing world. While it began with TB and malaria, its remit has expanded to antimicrobial resistance, lung health, women's health, besides the growing health impacts of climate change.

Its work is structured around three priorities: enabling earlier diagnosis and treatment through technology; compensating for limitations faced by healthcare workers; and deploying voice and capital to catalyse wider action. The challenge is only growing, given the shift in disease patterns. Mosquitoes, for instance, are moving into regions previously untouched. The Himalayan belt is a good example, Joshi says, where massive outbreaks of dengue have led to high mortality due to a lack of immunity. So, climate-sensitive and waterborne diseases now sit squarely within IHF's focus.

***EXPERTSPEAK***

**"Developing and scaling affordable, easy-to-use point-of-care diagnostics is especially critical for countries like India. IHF's focus on these core capabilities is aiding the cause of real healthcare"**

**MURALIDHARAN NAIR**
*Executive Director, EY*

For investments in digital technologies, it has zeroed in on three core areas: diagnostics, clinical decision support and disease surveillance, working closely with institutions such as the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation, National Health Mission, ICMR, AIIMS and the World Health Organization. Solutions are selected through a structured pipeline and subjected to a four-level evaluation.

The portfolio reflects that rigour. IHF-backed Qure.ai's qXR is an AI-powered tool that